does say of Gandhi is that given that he ‘thought it would have an influence for peace’, for this reason ‘he did ask for postponement’.[15] Juneja points out that Gandhi’s own version, which is available from an extract of Mahadev Desai’s diary, ‘does not conflict with that of the Viceroy’. In fact, what transpires is that Gandhi had no wish to prioritize the issue of Bhagat Singh’s death sentence over other more pressing matters, because the meetings of 17–18 February 1931 between Gandhi and Viceroy Irwin were about the Gandhi-Irwin Pact. This led to the agreement between the two of them on 5 March 1931, marking the end of the Civil Disobedience Movement in India. Under this agreement Irwin agreed to release those who had been imprisoned for taking part in the Salt March and to allow Indians to make salt for domestic use.

At best Gandhi took a disinterested view on Bhagat Singh. He himself records how with respect to Bhagat Singh he told Irwin that ‘[t]his has no connection with our discussion, and it may even be inappropriate on my part to mention’. One is bound to ask why, if Gandhi was so concerned to ensure the release of all those political prisoners who at his behest had taken part in the Salt March, he was not also at pains to seek the immediate release of one such as Bhagat Singh? After all, Gandhi managed to secure the freedom of no less than some 90,000 detainees. Yet, his words to Irwin clearly suggest that he was in cahoots with the viceroy. Outwardly, he would give the favourable appearance of doing something. Behind the scenes he was engaged in a discreditable design with Irwin to let the matter of Bhagat Singh lie exactly where it was. Nothing brings this home more clearly than Gandhi’s own words to Irwin. He has no doubt that it would be inappropriate to bring the issue of Bhagat Singh up at this time. On the other hand, does the statement ‘[b]ut if you want to make the present atmosphere more favourable, you should suspend Bhagat Singh’s execution’ make the present atmosphere more favourable? Is that what it was all about? Creating a favourable atmosphere rather than saving the life of a condemned man? We learn that unsurprisingly ‘[t]he Viceroy liked this very much and Irwin even said, “I am grateful to you that you have put this thing before me in this manner. Commutation of sentence is a difficult